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## FICTIONAL CHARACTERS AS ABSTRACT OBJECTS: SOME QUESTIONS

Reina Hayaki

**S**ir Arthur Conan Doyle wrote fifty-six short stories and four novels about Sherlock Holmes, collectively known as the Canon. The following are all true facts about the Canon:

- (1) It is true according to the Canon that Sherlock Holmes is a detective.
- (2) It is true according to the Canon that Queen Victoria hired a private consulting detective, gave him an emerald tiepin, and offered him a knighthood which he refused.
- (3) The Canon is about Sherlock Holmes.
- (4) The Canon is about a brilliant private detective who solves many crimes that baffle Scotland Yard.
- (5) The Canon is also about Queen Victoria (among other things).

This paper argues that the truth of these and similar facts creates some tension for the theory that fictional characters are abstract objects. A proponent of this theory will have to treat sentences (1) and (2) as disanalogous, and (3) to (5) as similarly disanalogous, in a way that undercuts part of the motivation for accepting an ontology of fictional characters.

The theory on which fictional characters are abstract objects can be called *creationism*:

such abstract objects are usually taken to be artifacts created by the authors of the fictions in which they appear, during the course of the authors' creation of those fictions. This view has been defended by Saul Kripke (1973), Peter van Inwagen (1977), Stephen Schiffer (1996), Amie Thomasson (1996, 1999, 2003), Nathan Salmon (1998), and many others. Creationists typically accept that Sherlock Holmes exists but is not a detective (because abstract).

Creationism has many attractive features, of which two are of special interest here. First, since the term "Sherlock Holmes" has an actual, real referent, a proposition in which the term occurs can be supplied with truth conditions that involve this referent. This is of comfort to those who accept a Millian view of names, on which names do not contribute any descriptive content to propositions in which they appear but merely contribute a referent. If "Sherlock Holmes" has no referent, then a sentence in which it appears would express at best a gappy proposition and could not be true. Second, the genuine existence of Sherlock Holmes *outside* the Canon makes it possible for noncanonical fictions, such as pastiches and parodies, to be about the very same character, which fact is more difficult

to explain on pretence-based theories (e.g., Walton 1990, Currie 1990).

Unfortunately, it is this very exportation of entities from within to outside the fictional context that gives rise to the disanalogous treatment of sentences (1) and (2), and of (3) to (5). Let us take (1) and (2) first. Sentence (2) says that it is true according to the Canon that Queen Victoria performed certain actions. She did not in fact perform those actions (at least as far as we know; if we are worried that (2) might accidentally turn out to be true, we can add a wealth of detail that lessens this probability, or even include the fact that the detective was Sherlock Holmes). So the Canon says something false about Queen Victoria; it attributes to Queen Victoria some properties she did not in fact have. The same is true of all real people and places appearing in the Canon: the Canon ascribes to them properties that they actually lack.

Sentence (1) says that it is true according to the Canon that Sherlock Holmes is a detective. On the creationist view, it is not true that Sherlock Holmes is a detective. Sherlock Holmes is an abstract object and thus cannot even be a human being, let alone a detective. In fact, Sherlock Holmes has almost none of the properties ascribed to him (or more accurately “it”) by the Canon. The few exceptions include being extremely famous, being of British origin, and being a product of the nineteenth century. The reason that we tend to accept “Sherlock Holmes is a detective” while rejecting “Sherlock Holmes is a police officer” is that the former sentence is true according to the Canon and the latter is not. But unprefixed by the fiction operator, both sentences are simply false.

On the most straightforward reading of creationism, Sherlock Holmes is not a detective but the Canon says, falsely, that it is. (We shall soon see why some creationists have rejected this reading and staked out a two-tier position.) If this is right, then the Canon very seriously

misdescribes Sherlock Holmes. It utterly misrepresents an abstract object as concrete, male, six feet tall, a smoker, a violin player, and a host of other things incompatible with abstractness. Indeed, the Canon must count as being “massively false” (Yagisawa 2001, p. 158), containing lie after lie about Sherlock Holmes, Dr. Watson, and a whole host of abstract entities. It may be acceptable to say that the Canon is (intentionally) inaccurate about Queen Victoria, London, Scotland Yard, and other actual people, places, and institutions. But to say that almost the entirety of the Canon is a pack of lies about some abstract objects goes very much against the grain.

The objection has been phrased in terms of what is true according to the Canon. Another way of getting at the same problem is to ask what the relationship is between Sherlock Holmes—the actual, abstract object—and the property of being a detective, if not that the Canon falsely predicates the property (and many others) of the object. Van Inwagen (1977) seems to have anticipated the problem. He says that there is a ternary relation, *A*, that holds between properties, fictional characters, and *places*, where a *place* is either a fiction or a part thereof. “*A*(*x*, *y*, *z*)” is to be read “*x* is ascribed to *y* in *z*,” but is to be taken as primitive. His examples include:

*A*(fatness, Mrs. Gamp, *Martin Chuzzlewit*)

*A*(fatness, the character introduced in ch. XIX of *Martin Chuzzlewit*, ch. XIX)

*A*(fatness, the main satiric villainess of *Martin Chuzzlewit*, *Martin Chuzzlewit*)

However, van Inwagen excludes the ordered triple <vanity, Napoleon, *War and Peace*> from the extension of *A* on the grounds that Napoleon is not a fictional character. He writes, “In the ordinary sense of ‘ascribe’ it is true that Tolstoy ascribed vanity to Napoleon in *War and Peace*” (1977, p. 306), but the relation *A* can only hold when a *fictional* character is in the middle position.

One *prima facie* advantage of treating fictional characters as genuine objects is that they can enter into relations on the same ontological footing as everyday physical objects. Both Sherlock Holmes and Queen Victoria are perfectly good objects. Both can appear in, or be (mis)described in, or have properties (inaccurately) ascribed to them in, various works of fiction, either canonical or otherwise. Of course, one can define a ternary ascription relation *A* in such a way that the middle term must be a fictional character, not a real person. But this does not touch the intuition that if Sherlock Holmes is just as real as Queen Victoria, then the Canon says things about both of them equally. Both are ascribed personhood in the Canon, inaccurately for Sherlock Holmes and accurately for Queen Victoria. What's wrong with using "ascribe" in the "ordinary sense" and saying that the Canon falsely ascribes properties such as personhood to Sherlock Holmes?

Some creationists have responded by denying that the Canon ascribes any properties at all, either correctly or incorrectly, to the abstract object Sherlock Holmes, because the name "Sherlock Holmes" behaves differently within the Canon than the way it does outside it. Outside the fiction—for example, in literary criticism—it refers to an abstract object; within the fiction, it is not referential at all. Kripke (1973), Searle (1974–1975), van Inwagen (1977), Schiffer (1996), and Thomasson (2003) have all argued for this two-tier approach to names of fictional objects. Van Inwagen (1977) clarifies that the fictional character known as "Mrs. Gamp" only acquires that name by virtue of the ascription relation *A* holding between the property of being named "Mrs. Gamp," that fictional character (the satiric villainess, the character introduced in ch. XIX), and *Martin Chuzzlewit*. He writes,

We have embodied in our rules for talking about fiction a convention that says that a creature of

fiction *may* be referred to by what is (loosely speaking) "the name it has in the story." It is owing to a similar convention that we use *personal* pronouns in connection with entities that are literally *not* persons: we call Mrs. Gamp "she" because, though she is not a woman, *the property of being a woman is ascribed to her*. (p. 307, n. 8; final emphasis mine)

So the fictional character *is* ascribed the property of being a woman in *Martin Chuzzlewit*. However, it is "loose speaking" to talk of the name *it* has in the story because the story says absolutely nothing about that abstract object:

It is not the case that when Dickens wrote (1) ["She was a fat old woman, this Mrs. Gamp"] he was ascribing any property to anything, either in our technical sense of "ascribe" or in the ordinary sense; to ascribe a property to something (in either sense of "ascribe"), Dickens would have had to have been expressing some proposition when he wrote (1), and, as I have said, he did not express any proposition by writing (1). (p. 306)

There is no point in debating what sort of thing Dickens was writing about when he wrote (1) or debating what sort of fact or proposition he was asserting, since he was not writing about anything and was asserting nothing. Sentence (1) does not represent an *attempt* at reference or description. (p. 301)

On this view, the relationship between the abstract object Sherlock Holmes and the property of being a detective is *not* that the property is (falsely) predicated of the object in the Canon, because the Canon does not predicate any properties of the object. There is no nontechnical way to describe the relationship; van Inwagen's primitive triadic relation *A* is the best we can do.

What should this type of creationist say about truth in fiction? What happens to our sentences (1) and (2), which start with the prefix, "It is true according to the Canon that . . ." and seem to ascribe straightforward, truth-evaluable semantic content to the Can-

on? One could deny that (1) and (2) are true and proscribe the use of any truth-in-fiction operator; but this is deeply unattractive. Such operators may not be required for simple cases, e.g., its being true according to the Canon that Holmes is a detective. Instead of saying this, one could just use van Inwagen's relation *A* and say that the ordered triple <being a detective, Holmes, the Canon> belongs to *A*. But there may be cases of implicit or inferred truth-in-fiction that do not lend themselves so easily to a paraphrase in terms of *A*. It is true according to the Canon that Holmes lacked a third nostril (other characters would have reacted to it constantly), even though no sentence or collection of sentences in the Canon mentions this lack. It is far from clear that the ordered triple <lack of a third nostril, Holmes, the Canon> should be regarded as belonging to *A*. There is the further problem that *A*-paraphrases are, by fiat, unavailable for cases of truth-in-fiction that involve actual people and places, such as its being true according to the Canon that Queen Victoria is a person, or that Victoria gave an emerald tiepin to a private consulting detective.

If one wants to preserve the use of meaningful truth-in-fiction operators while denying that the Canon predicates any properties of Sherlock Holmes, then one must differentiate very clearly between the two types of occurrence of the term "Sherlock Holmes." Not just in the original text of the Canon, but also within the context, "It is true according to the Canon that . . ." (and perhaps others), the term is nonreferential and does not permit existential generalization outside the scope of the prefix to:

- (1')  $(\exists x)(x = \text{Sherlock Holmes} \wedge \text{it is true according to the Canon that } x \text{ is a detective})$ .

However, this has two unwelcome consequences. First, we must treat (1) and (2) differently, since (2) does seem to permit existential generalization to

- (2')  $(\exists x)(x = \text{Queen Victoria} \wedge \text{it is true according to the Canon that } x \text{ hired a detective [etc.]})$ .

This is perhaps not so bad. The other result is more disappointing: by blocking the inference from (1) to (1'), we lose a compelling motivation for adopting creationism, namely that the exportation of fictional characters from inside to outside a fiction allows for the repeated use of the same character in different fictions, such as pastiches and parodies.

On Nathan Salmon's version of creationism, (1), its existential generalization (1'), and (2) are all true, and the Canon is indeed "massively false":

Conan Doyle one fine day set about to tell a story. In the process he created a fictional character as the protagonist, and other fictional characters as well. . . . These characters, like the story itself, are man-made abstract artifacts. . . . The name "Sherlock Holmes" was originally coined by Conan Doyle in writing the story (and subsequently understood by readers reading the *Holmes* stories) as the fictional name for the protagonist. That thing—in fact merely an abstract artifact—is *according to the story*, a man by the name of "Sherlock Holmes." . . . At a later stage, use of the name is imported from the fiction into reality, to name *the very same thing* that it is the name of according to the story. That thing—now the real as well as the fictional bearer of the name—is according to the story a human being who is a brilliant detective, and in reality an artifactual abstract entity created by Conan Doyle. (1998, p. 300)

Accepting the "massive falsity" of the Canon does seem to be the least painful approach that retains the special advantages of creationism. However, related considerations involving the notion of "aboutness" cast doubt on whether this is the only counterintuitive result the creationist must accept. Sentences (3) to (5) illustrate this related problem.

Sentences (3) to (5) say that the Canon is about Sherlock Holmes, and about a brilliant



private detective, and about Queen Victoria (among other things). All seem straightforwardly true. Take (5): the Canon is about Queen Victoria. Queen Victoria is a real object, so there is something real that the Canon is about:

- (5')  $(\exists x)(x = \text{Queen Victoria} \wedge \text{the Canon is about } x)$

If we accepted earlier that (1) and its existential generalization (1') are both true, then there is an object—a fictional character, an abstract object—which is (mis)described in the Canon as being a detective. The Canon is then *about* this object, although it says many inaccurate things about it. Thus, the following is also true:

- (3')  $(\exists x)(x = \text{Sherlock Holmes} \wedge \text{the Canon is about } x)$

This may raise the hope that with the importation into the real world of fictional characters, we can make “aboutness” a genuine relation between fictions and objects. But of course this hope is quickly dashed, as the falsity of (4') shows, since the Canon is not about an actual *detective*:

- (4')  $(\exists x)(x \text{ is a brilliant private detective who solves many crimes that baffle Scotland Yard} \wedge \text{the Canon is about } x)$

What the original sentence (4) illustrates is that the word “about” does not express a relation. The Canon is about a brilliant private detective, but this does not mean that some binary relation holds between the Canon and a brilliant private detective. This may be painfully obvious. However, it is worth re-stating: “The Canon is about . . .” is an intensional context. The Canon is (partly) about the friendship between Holmes and Watson, and on the view we are discussing, Holmes and Watson are actual abstract objects; but the Canon is not about the friendship between two abstract objects. The Canon is about the cases that Holmes investigates, but not about the cases investigated by an abstract object.

These results suggest that the “about” context is sensitive to truth-in-fiction. Our instinct is to regard a sentence of the form “The Canon is about  $x$ ” as true iff it is true according to the Canon that  $x$  exists, and “The Canon is about an  $F$ ” as true iff it is true according to the Canon that there is an  $F$ . It is true according to the Canon that Sherlock Holmes exists, so the Canon is about Sherlock Holmes. As a general principle, if the Canon is about  $x$ , and  $x$  is real, then there is a real object,  $x$ , such that the Canon is about  $x$ . According to creationists, Sherlock Holmes is real though abstract. So there exists a real, abstract object such that the Canon is about it.

But this seems wrong. We want to say the Canon is about Sherlock-Holmes-the-man, not Sherlock-Holmes-the-abstract-object, because the Canon is not about an abstract object. (To be accurate, it *is* about such abstract things as friendship, the art of detection, and the interplay between law and morality; but it is not about Sherlock-Holmes-the-abstract-object.) Of course, there is no such thing as Sherlock-Holmes-the-man, so the Canon can't be about that. The only Sherlock Holmes for the Canon to be about is Sherlock-Holmes-the-abstract-object. It strains the ordinary usage of “about” to say that the Canon is about Sherlock-Holmes-the-abstract-object. On balance this is worse than the same strain involved in saying that the Canon inaccurately predicates personhood, and many other properties incompatible with abstractness, of an abstract object.

It might be objected that, since “about” clearly does not express a relation, we should not existentially generalize even in the case of unproblematic entities like Queen Victoria: the Canon is about Queen Victoria, and Queen Victoria exists, but from that we cannot infer

- (5'')  $\exists x(x = \text{Queen Victoria} \wedge \text{the Canon is about } x)$ .

In other words, *de re* ascriptions of aboutness must be blocked even for Queen Victoria, lest they allow (3') to sneak in. Sentence (3') is suspect because, although it is true that Sherlock Holmes exists, it is not true that the Canon is about *it*, for the reasons given above.

The problem with this response is that even if aboutness is not a relation, there does seem to be some relation in the vicinity. Various historical personages have the distinction of having appeared in the Canon, including Queen Victoria; the composer and violinist Pablo de Sarasate; Alphonse Bertillon, the French police officer who invented anthropometry. Indeed, Bertillon is probably better known now for his brief mention in *The Hound of the Baskervilles* than for his career. Plenty of real geographical locations appear in the Canon: London, the Andaman Islands, the Reichenbach Falls. These people and places have a special property in common. And it does seem to be a genuine property, i.e., extensional. It does not sound strange to say that the composer of *Zigeunerweisen* appeared in the Canon, even though this piece is never mentioned by Doyle. Similarly, Kaiser Wilhelm II's maternal grandmother appeared in the Canon, though not so described. The relation that these people and places bear to the Canon is the same as the one that both Sigmund Freud and Vienna bear to *The Seven-Per-Cent Solution*: the people and places appear in those stories. The examples in this paragraph bear up fairly well to substitution with co-referential terms (perhaps because the people and places appear in subject position). So even if aboutness won't work, there are other candidates. Any such relation should treat Queen Victoria and the abstract but real Sherlock Holmes alike. One can hardly deny that both Victoria and Holmes appear in the Canon. This will give rise to the same tension as before: it is odd to say that Holmes-the-abstract-object appears in

the Canon when the degree of misdescription is so severe.

Some creationists may want to allow (5') while rejecting (3'). This requires a modification of the general principle that if the Canon is about *x*, and *x* is real, then *x* is such that the Canon is about it. Fictional objects must be excluded from the schema, and some justification must be provided for why this is not *ad hoc*. The creationist could try to invoke the two-tier account of fictional names, as before, and say that in the sentence, "The Canon is about Sherlock Holmes," the name "Sherlock Holmes" is not used referentially. But this is a bit of a stretch, and assimilating (3) to (4) robs creationism of its ontological punch.

Let us sum up the creationist's situation with respect to the five sentences with which we started. With respect to truth-in-fiction, the creationist must either disavow the notion; or admit that the Canon is "massively false" with respect to what it predicates of a host of abstract objects; or, as many creationists do, treat (1) and (2) in disanalogous ways. Given the real existence of Queen Victoria, (2) entails its existential generalization (2'). However, (1) does not entail (1'). This leaves somewhat mysterious the nature of the relationship between Sherlock Holmes and the property of being a detective, since the relationship is not simply that the property is falsely predicated of the object according to the Canon.

With respect to sentences (3) to (5), all parties can agree that (4) differs qualitatively from (3) and (5). The question is whether (3) should be treated more like (5) on the grounds that both contain references to real objects, or more like (4), which carries no existential import at all. Those who believe that Sherlock Holmes does not exist will want to treat (3) like (4), which seems the most natural way to go. Creationists face a difficult choice. The "hard-line" option, *à la* Salmon, would be to stonewall and insist that there *is* a real, abstract Sherlock Holmes that the Canon is about, thereby treating (3) analogously with

(5). Creationists who advocate a two-tier account of fictional names could explain, why within the context “The Canon is about . . .,” the name “Sherlock Holmes” does not behave referentially, perhaps by appealing to the intensionality of the “about” context. But if intensionality is the issue, additional work would be required in order to differentiate the name “Sherlock Holmes” from the name “Queen Victoria,” since the context clearly remains intensional whichever name appears inside.

The other option open to the creationist would be to explain why (3) deserves treatment along the lines of (4) rather than (5), even though (3), like (5) and unlike (4), includes a reference to a genuine object. Sentence (4) escapes existential generalization because the brilliant detective it mentions is fictional. Although (3) and (5) both mention real objects, the object mentioned in (3) is both real and fictional, whereas the object mentioned in (5) is real and nonfictional. This gives us a point of similarity between (3) and (4): both mention fictional objects. Again, we must alter the general principle that if the Canon is about  $x$  and  $x$  is a real object, then there is a real object,  $x$ , such that the Canon is about  $x$ . The revised principle holds not for all *real* objects, but for all *nonfictional* objects. It is not clear whether this is superior to simply admitting that fictions can be about objects that don’t exist.

The two difficulties described above arise because fictional characters are accepted into our ontology under creationism. It is worth comparing creationism with some other theories that also posit fictional objects. There are three broad types of theory on which the object Sherlock Holmes is the straightforward referent of the term “Sherlock Holmes”: creationism, Meinongianism, and possibilism. The problems are most acute for creationism. Some Meinongian theories are vulnerable. Possibilism is unaffected.

Possibilism says that fictional objects are nonactual but possible objects. Sherlock Holmes does not exist in this world but does exist in some other possible world. David Lewis has offered such an account in Lewis (1978), whose main purpose is to provide an analysis of truth in fiction. Whether a sentence is true according to the Canon depends on what is true at some possible worlds in which the Canon is told as known fact rather than fiction (along with some further restrictions on the range of possible worlds). Any such world will be one where both Sherlock Holmes and (a counterpart of) Queen Victoria exist.

There is no problem here in describing the relationship between Sherlock Holmes and the property of being a detective. Sherlock Holmes does not exist at the actual world; but at some world, he (not “it”) does exist and is a detective. The Canon says of this merely possible object that it is a detective. What the Canon says is false at the actual world, but this is no worse than its falsely saying of Queen Victoria that she hired a private detective and gave him an emerald tiepin. Both falsehoods are true at some other world.

Possibilism treats sentences (3) to (5) all alike: the Canon is about Sherlock Holmes, or a brilliant detective, or Queen Victoria, because some possible world, at which the Canon is told as known fact rather than fiction, contains all these things (or counterparts thereof).

Meinongianism has been discussed more widely and developed more fully than possibilism. The Meinongian view of fictional objects is that they are nonexistent objects. They are actual, and in some sense real, despite being nonexistent. Various versions of Meinongianism can be found in Routley (1980), Parsons (1980), Zalta (1988), and Priest (2005).

Parsons’s position is that Sherlock Holmes is a nonexistent object but is also a detective. This position is not shared by the majority of Meinongians, who argue that a nonexistent



object is not in a position to meet clients or ferret out clues and thus cannot be a detective. Sherlock Holmes has relatively few interesting properties. (In this respect Meinongianism is similar to creationism.) What, then, is the relationship between the nonexistent object Sherlock Holmes and the property of being a detective? Two Meinongian responses are as follows. Zalta (1988) argues that Sherlock Holmes does not *exemplify* (i.e., have) the property of being a detective, but it *encodes* that property. Distinguishing between *exemplifying* and *encoding* a property looks no worse, but no better, than the creationist position on which Sherlock Holmes is inaccurately described in the Canon as a detective. Another line is taken by Priest (2005): there is a plurality of worlds, some possible and some “open” (impossible). All have the same domain, but an object can be existent at some worlds and nonexistent at others. If the arguments offered by Kripke (1980) are right, then Sherlock Holmes is an impossible object. So Sherlock Holmes is nonexistent at all possible worlds and existent in some open

worlds. At some of those open worlds he is a detective. As with Lewis’s possibilism, there is no mystery at all about the relationship between Sherlock Holmes and the property of being a detective: at some open world, Sherlock Holmes has the property. And again, there is no special problem with sentences (3) to (5). The Canon is about Sherlock Holmes, or a brilliant detective, or Queen Victoria, because all these things are existent at some (open) world whose truths match the truths within the Canon.

This quick discussion of the closest rivals to creationism is not intended to justify anointing any of these candidates as the best theory overall. In particular, creationism’s greater vulnerability to the worries discussed in this paper is not fatal to it. However, in order to secure victory, creationism must be able to offer greater advantages elsewhere that offset the counterintuitive consequences discussed above.

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